BUILDING ONE — UX RESEARCH

How people choose and book a moment of rest

Research plan, early hypotheses and design direction for the spa & massage booking app.

Couple's flatmate who hydrothermic from desk weekend and been meaning to book a massage for months, but every booking feels too fiddly.

RESEARCH GOALS

- Understand how locals and visitors decide where and when to get a massage
- Find what builds trust before a first visit
- Identify friction in today's booking (phone, LINE, walk-in)
- Learn what timing gestures mean

KEY QUESTIONS

- How do they research a place to book a treatment?
- How do people judge quality before they arrive?
- What makes them abandon a booking?
- How much do therapist, price and time and matter?

METHODS

- **17 interviews** · 45 min, remote or in spa
- **In-spa observation** · reception & check-in
- **Competitor review** · booking apps & spa sites
- **Usability test** · this prototype, 5 users

PARTICIPANTS

- 12 Bangkok residents, 25–45, massage at least monthly
- 3 international visitors staying 5+ nights
- 2 in-spa hosts (FC, Amaya) incl. open staff
- Mix of first-timers and loyal guests

KEY INSIGHTS TO VALIDATE

OPPORTUNITY 01

Trust comes from seeing the room

Guests want real photos of rooms, cleanliness and therapists before a first visit — not polished stock shots or a starting age.

INSIGHT SUPPORTED
Interviews · Services Audit · Locations

OPPORTUNITY 02

Time is the real currency

Most bookings are squeezed around errands. Seeing open slots at a glance matters more than a long list of services.

INSIGHT SUPPORTED
Card-first prototype & pull of day

OPPORTUNITY 03

Surprise costs break trust

Add-ons, tips and extra charges that appear at payment.

INSIGHT SUPPORTED
Interviews · Review & price · Review & pay

OPPORTUNITY 04

A favourite therapist is loyalty

Regulars return for a person, not a place. Losing "their" therapist is a reason to switch spas.

INSIGHT SUPPORTED
Therapist profile · Book with therapist

OPPORTUNITY 05

Visitors need reassurance in English

Tourists worry about etiquette, pressure, and getting there. Clear directions and simple language lower anxiety.

INSIGHT SUPPORTED
Treatment detail · Directions · Arrival tip

OPPORTUNITY 06

Rebooking is forgotten, not rejected

Guests intend to come back but don't act. A gentle nudge after the visit brings them back.

INSIGHT SUPPORTED
Review prompt · Points · Book again

HOW MIGHT WE

> *How might we draw a quick, atmospheric hierarchy before the first visit?*

> *How might we make booking a list that fits for other work-side seconds?*

> *How might we help guests stay with the therapist they trust?*

> *How might we help guests see with the therapist they trust?*

KEY INSIGHTS FOR THIS SESSION

Cube, not charmed
Site structure can create, previous users.

Human from the start
Real rooms, full prices, no hidden fees.

Personal touch
Remember me guest, their therapist and preferences.

RESEARCH TIMELINE

WEEK 1
Plan & recruit
Screener, consent, interview guide

WEEK 2
Interviews & observation
17 sessions, in-spa visits

WEEK 3
Synthesis
Affinity map, update personas & journey

WEEK 4
Usability test
Test booking prototype, iterate

BUILDING ONE — PERSONAS

Who we are designing for

Three proto-personas covering the busy local, the visiting traveller and the therapy-led regular.

Couple's flatmate who hydrothermic from desk weekend and been meaning to book a massage for months, but every booking feels too fiddly.

PRIMARY PERSONA

Pharina C.
41 · Marketing manager · Bangkok

"I just want to book something calming after work — without calling or waiting."

Works long hours in Sukhumvit and books a massage every few weeks to three weeks. Values her phone during the commute and loves an occasional long, all-weekend treatment.

GOALS
- Book an evening slot in under a minute
- Get the same therapist each time
- Know the total price before paying

FRUSTRATIONS
- Phone lines busy or LINE replies slow
- Popular evening slots fill up
- Add-on prices only revealed at the end

BEHAVIOURS
- Books 1–2 days ahead, weekday evenings
- Pays with PromptPay
- Reads reviews and checks room photos

Trait	
Tech comfort	High
Price sensitivity	Medium
Time spent	High

KEY SIGNALS FOR THIS SESSION
Home · Date & time · Therapist profile · Review & pay

SECONDARY PERSONA

Emma [Surname]
28 · Italian, from abroad · 6 nights in Bangkok

"I came a real Thai massage, but I don't know what's normal or how to get there."

Travelling with her partner and wants an authentic experience she can trust. Unsure about etiquette, how hot the pressure will be, and the right price to pay.

GOALS
- Find an authentic, clean spa nearby
- Understand treatments in plain English
- Book a couple suite for two

FRUSTRATIONS
- Prices that change at checkout
- Hard to judge quality from photos
- Getting lost finding the branch

BEHAVIOURS
- Books same day or next day
- Pays by card or Apple Pay
- Relies on maps and reviews

Trait	
Tech comfort	Medium
Price sensitivity	Medium
Time spent	Low

KEY SIGNALS FOR THIS SESSION
All treatments · Offer detail · Locations · Booking confirmed

SECONDARY PERSONA

Somchai [Surname]
54 · Retired engineer · Nonthaburi

"My back needs regular care. I go to the therapist who knows my body."

Visits nearby for traditional Thai massage and herbal compress to manage back pain. Prefers a familiar routine and a therapist who remembers his needs.

GOALS
- Keep a weekly routine with one therapist
- Use membership points and discounts
- Simple, readable booking

FRUSTRATIONS
- Small text and fine print
- Unexpected extra charges
- Forgetting to book
- Therapist unavailable at his usual time

BEHAVIOURS
- Same day and time every week
- Pays cash or at the spa
- Prefers calling, open to an easy app

Trait	
Tech comfort	Low
Price sensitivity	Medium
Time spent	High

KEY SIGNALS FOR THIS SESSION
Therapist profile · My bookings · Membership · Add profile

BUILDING ONE — FEATURE: GUEST JOURNEY

From first glance to loyal guest

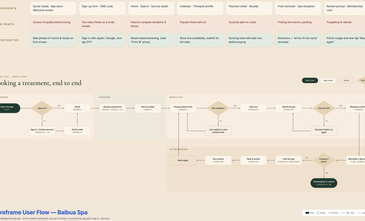
PERSONA
Pharina C.

GOAL
Find a therapist, book a time, and feel looked after — from first glance to loyal guest.

	STAGE 01 Discover	STAGE 02 Join	STAGE 03 Explore	STAGE 04 Book	STAGE 05 Pay	STAGE 06 Visit	STAGE 07 Return
DOING	Sees a friend's post, downloads the app	Enters name, email, phone, types, first code	Scrolls figurative picks, wants therapists	Chooses a slot that fits after work	Applies promo code, pays with PromptPay	Sets reminder, follows map, arrives early	Walks the door, checks points, books again
FEELING	Welcome	Sign up · OTP	Home · Search · Service	Date & time · Add-ons	Review & pay	Booking detail · Directions	Review · Membership
THOUGHTS	"Is this place safe and trustworthy?"	"Hope this is quick."	"Which treatment suits my aim back?"	"Can I get my favourite therapist?"	"What will I pay in total?"	"I am finally switch off."	"I want this every month."
TOUCHPOINTS	Social media · App store · Referral codes	Sign-up form · SMS code	Home · Search · Service detail	Calendar · Therapist profile	Payment sheet · Receipt	Push reminder · Spa reception	Review prompt · Membership card
PAIN POINTS	Unsure of quality before trying	Too many fields on a small screen	Hard to compare durations & prices	Popular time sell out	Surprise add-on costs	Finding the branch, parking	Forgetting to rebook
OPPORTUNITIES	Real photos of rooms & Trust on first screen	Sign in with Apple / Google, one tap OTP	Mood-based browsing, clear "From ฿" prices	Show live availability, waitlist for full slots	Running total with add-ons before paying	Directions + "arrive 15 min early" reminder	Points nudge and one-tap "Book again"

BUILDING ONE — FEATURE: CURRENT STATE

Booking a treatment, end to end


Start
Open the app
Home
Browse treatments
Service detail
Choose therapist
Pick a time slot
Add-ons
Review & pay
Booking confirmed
Arrive
Check in at reception
Treatment
Pay & tip
Leave review
Rebook
Book again
Not sure which therapist to pick
Can't find a free slot
Price changes at checkout
Forgot to book
Can't remember the way
Arrives late, rushed
Wants to rebook
Finds the branch, parking
Forgets to rebook
Therapist unavailable
Slot taken
Wants a familiar therapist
Finds the spa
Wants to rebook
Therapist unavailable at usual time
Therapist is unavailable at usual time
Wants to rebook
Therapist unavailable at usual time
Rebooks a day before
Rebooks in app
Rebooks in app
Rebooks in app